

The Spirit Of Solomon

A Collection Of Poems

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Dedication

*For those who loved me at my worst, who saw
the man beneath the crown, and for those I lost
along the way your absence taught me presence*

*“The heart has its reasons which
reason knows nothing of.”*

Blaise Pascal

*“For where your treasure is, there
your heart will be also.”*

Matthew 6:21

*"Wisdom is the principal thing;
therefore get wisdom: and with all
thy getting get"*

understanding

Proverbs 4:7

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Introduction

In the ancient text, King Solomon was blessed with wisdom beyond measure, yet even he fell prey to the temptations of flesh and power. His story is one of glory and folly, of profound insight and profound blindness

This collection traces a modern Solomon's journey: a man who crowned himself king of desire, who built his kingdom on conquest rather than connection, who mistook power for worth and possession for love.

These poems chart the rise and fall of that kingdom, the cracks in that crown, and ultimately, the wisdom that can only come from wounds. They speak to the universal struggle between what we want and what we need, between who we pretend to be and who we truly are.

In the tradition of the Song of Solomon, these verses explore the sacred and profane nature of love, its capacity to elevate and destroy, to heal and to harm. They ask what it means to be a man in a world that rewards performance over presence, and what it costs to maintain that performance.

This is not just a collection of poems about relationships; it is an excavation of the self, a reckoning with the ghosts of what could have been, and ultimately, a testament to the

possibility of rebuilding from ruins.

The journey begins in desire and ends in wisdom. What lies between is the story of a man learning, finally, that the true measure of a king is not how many he rules, but how deeply he can surrender to the most powerful force of all love.

I. The Kingdom of Desire

The Idea of Love

The idea of love.

It's one that's followed me my whole life,

but I still ask myself

Was that really what I was seeking?

Love.

What even is that?

Some made-up fairy tale

where the prince and princess get together in the end?

No. It's more.

It's always been more.

I've sent many women packing,

left them with their hopes and dreams still unpacked.

Yet somehow, I can still feel them.

Still hear them.

Still see their wanting eyes, even when I let them go.

Is that love?

No.

Love is more than that.

What I'm describing is connection

one I think I never had

with those who said they loved me.

Loved me so much, I started believing

Pain was love.

That suffering made it stronger.

My love ain't peaceful.

It ain't kind.

My love is heartache, breakups,

and finding your big brother in bed with your wife.

But before you start casting stones,

let me ask you

What is your idea of love?

The one you hold so dear?

See, mine makes a winner.

Yours puts you in a crowd that cheers.

I'll get the ring and leave before the kiss.

You'll never see the white in your own gown.

And that

That is my solemn vow.

God Ain't Watching

*I move like smoke in a dim-lit room,
cool hands, slow grin, voice like velvet sin.
Ain't no thunder cracking the sky,
no ghosts whispering warnings in my ear.
If I was meant to pay for this,
shouldn't the bill be here by now?*

*They say every touch leaves a scar,
but my hands stay clean,
my sheets stay warm,
and my phone still hums with names
that don't ask for much
just a taste, just a night,
just enough to make them wonder
what loving me might feel like.*

*I collect them like secrets,
soft bodies pressed into memory,
lips parted in surrender,*

*hearts left on my nightstand
like spare change I never spend.*

*I pray but not for forgiveness.
Not for peace.
I pray for more.*

*More skin, more sweat,
more nights where the only sound
is my name tangled in their breath.*

*And if I wake up untouched,
if my luck ain't run out yet, then maybe, just maybe,
God ain't watching at all.*

The Art of Rotation

*It's a delicate thing
like jazz, like chess, like the tide knowing
just how far to reach before it pulls back.
Too much, and they drown in you.
Too little, and they start looking for land.*

*See, a real player doesn't chase.
A real player moves like gravity
silent, invisible, but always felt.
He don't beg for time;
He lets absence make them curious.*

*Lets them wonder where he at,
who he with,
why he ain't called.*

The trick?

*Make every woman feel like she the only one
without ever saying she is.
A well-placed "I miss you,"
a lingering glance,
a slow kiss that says everything
and nothing at all.*

Text her just enough

to keep her warm but never hot.

Love her just enough

to keep her close but never locked.

Give her just enough

to make her think she winning,

when really, she is just playing your game.

And when one gets too close

*when she starts whispering words like **forever**
pull back.*

*Disappear just long enough for doubt to creep in,
for her to miss the way your hands fit her waist,
for her to remember how quiet her bed feels
without you in it.*

*Because the art of rotation
ain't just about keeping them in line
It's about keeping them wanting.
About making them think leaving
was never an option.*

Love? That Ain't for Me

*Love is a heavy coat in the dead of summer,
too warm, too weighty, too much to bear.
I prefer the breeze, the light touch of passing hands,
the warmth that doesn't linger past sunrise.*

*See, love is a contract,
inked in sacrifice, bound in blood,
a debt that always comes due.
And me? I deal in moments,
in lips that forget my name by morning,
in hearts that never get close enough to break.*

*I give just enough to taste,
never enough to swallow.
Just enough to make her wonder
but not enough to make her stay.
They call it game,
but it's really just knowing the rules.
Knowing that a man who don't fall
can't be caught.*

*She asks what we are,
and I kiss her slow,
let my silence press against her skin.
Some questions are not for answers.
Some hands ain't meant to be held.*

*Because love?
Love is a locked door,
and I've never been the type
to beg for keys.*

They Say I'm Just Like Him

*They say I'm just like him, the king of the game,
a man too slick, too sharp to be tamed.
Silver-tongued prophet with hands laced in sin,
I whisper a prayer, then do it again.*

*I move like a shadow, too quick to be caught,
love ain't a lesson I ever got taught.
I take what I want, then I leave it behind,
never a trace, never a sign.*

*She calls me the devil, but still, she stays,
wrapped in the spell of my halfway gaze.
She wants forever I laugh at the thought,
ain't nothing I built that doesn't end up rot.*

*But they still follow, still reach for my touch,
swearing I'm different, swearing I'm much.
Like I ain't the echo of men from before,
writing their names, then locking the door.*

*They say I'm just like him I take it in stride,
a king with a kingdom, a throne built on pride.
And maybe one day, I'll answer the cost,
but until then?*

I never get lost.

Ain't No Kings Without Queens

*What is a king without women to kneel?
A throne with no warmth, a crown that ain't real.
Gold means nothing when hands stay cold,
when nights stretch long, and the bed feels old.*

*See, power ain't power if no one obeys,
if no one is waiting, if no one will stay.
So I keep them close, but not too tight,
a whispered promise, a stolen night.*

*I touch like worship, I move like prayer,
a prophet of pleasure with time to spare.
She thinks she's special, the only one,
but she's just a verse in a song I've spun.*

*One tells me she loves me I let her believe,
watch as she builds, while I plan to leave.
One wants forever I smile, stay mute,
ain't no kingdom that doesn't bear fruit.*

*Because what is a king if he stands alone?
A fool in gold, a man unthroned.
So I let them love, I let them dream,
but I never let them reign with me.*

The Gospel of Game

*I never tell lies
I just let them believe.
A well-placed pause, a touch on the sleeve,
a look that lingers, a smirk, a tease
they write their own stories, I just plant the seed.*

*See, love ain't a language, it's a trick of the tongue,
a song well-sung, a web well-spun.
Give her just enough to keep her near,
never too much, never too clear.*

*A compliment wrapped in something unsaid,
a whisper that lingers long after bed.
A hand on her thigh, then pulling away
leave her wanting, make her stay.*

*They call it game, but it's more like faith,
Belief in what I never say.
A touch, a glance, a half-meant vow
she'll paint the picture, I just show her how.*

*Because truth is a mirror, and I learned too young,
Most hearts break long before they're strung.
And me? I ain't cruel, I just let them dream.
Ain't my fault they want to believe in me.*

The Last Time I Prayed

*I used to kneel with both hands tight,
whispering hopes into dead-of-night.
Asking for mercy, asking for grace,
before I learned how to lie to His face.*

*See, once upon a time, I played it straight,
thought love was fate, thought hearts were safe.
But lessons come quick when the world turns cold
prayers go quiet when trust gets sold.*

*The first time I fell, I fell too deep,
gave what was real, lost what was me.
And when she left? I learned the trade
how to make a woman stay.*

*Now my prayers are lips, my hands are hymns,
I baptize bodies, then leave like the wind.
No need for blessings, no need for light,
I make my own heaven, one touch at a time.*

*But sometimes just sometimes I hear that voice,
Deep in silence, stripping my choice.
And maybe one night, when the games all fade,
I'll remember the last time I truly prayed.*

II. Conquest and Crown

Her Lips, My Sin

*Her lips were scripture,

written in red,
a gospel of hunger,

a prayer left unsaid.
Soft as deceit,

sweet as a lie,
she kissed like a promise

, then left me to die.*

*She tasted like midnight, like whispered regret,
a sin I ain't touched,*

but still won't forget.

She was fire, she was smoke,

*she was death wrapped in lace,
but I still let her pull me to that dangerous place.*

My hands on her hips,

*my name on her tongue,
she laughed when I told her she might be the one.
Not for forever,*

*not for a life,
but for nights built on heat, for pleasure,*

not my wife.

*I knew what she was a ghost draped in silk,
poison in perfume, honey in filth.
But I drank anyway, let her pull me too deep,
now her lips are a wound,

and I pray in my sleep.*

She Called Me Beautiful

*She had that honey-gold skin, kissed by dusk,
curls wild like secrets the wind wouldn't trust.
Eyes that held fire, the kind that devours,
a look that could break men in under an hour.*

*She ran the night like she owned the streets,
soft hands, sharp tongue, gold anklets on her feet.
Her scent? Like warm vanilla left out in the sun,
a sweetness that stayed long after she was gone.*

*I was the wolf at least, I thought,
'Till she grabbed the wheel and left me caught.
One hand on my thigh, the other in gear,
she smiled, slow like she already knew my fears.*

*"You're beautiful," she whispered, voice thick as sin,
and damn if I ain't felt it deep in my skin.
A man don't blush, a man don't shake
but she made me breathless, and made my body betray me.*

*She traced my jaw, laughed when I sighed,
like she loved to unravel whatever I tried.
I thought I was hunter, I thought I had game,
but in her hands, I was prey just the same.*

Red Dress, Black Heart

She walked in, and the whole room leaned.

*Scarlet silk, slit high as sin,
curls wild down her back, soft as a hymn,
hips swaying like a song I'd die to sing.*

*She smelled like burnt sugar and bad decisions,
like midnight wrapped in jasmine and sweat.
Every man watched, but she looked at me
a slow drag of her gaze, undressing my regret.*

*I felt her before she even touched me,
heat licking up my skin,
fingertips ghosting my wrist,
nails tracing the veins like she could read my sin.*

*"Miss me?" she whispered, lips just shy of mine.
And God help me, I did.
Because she was famine, she was feast,
she was the hunger I never could quit.*

*My hands found her waist, greedy, unholy,
her breath in my ear, a wicked little prayer.
She laughed low, knowing
and pressed closer, til all I could taste was her air.*

But I knew better.

*I knew that dress was warpaint,
those lips were a blade,
Her love was a grave I had already laid.*

*Still, I followed her out,
like a man with no past, no shame, no cost.
Because she had a black heart,
but damn, it matched mine.*

The First Woman I Ever Worshipped

*She let me think I had the reins,
smirked when I gripped her hips like I owned her,
like she wasn't the one guiding my hands,
wasn't the one pulling the strings under my skin.*

*Her body was silk and sin,
warmth spilling over me in waves,
hips rolling like a whispered command,
breath hot against my neck, laced with praise.*

*She sighed my name like it meant something,
like I was more than another conquest in her bed,
like I wasn't just the next fool chasing
the ghost of her touch, the taste of her breath.*

*I traced fire down her spine,
dragged my lips across every inch of her,
thinking I was marking her, branding her
but she only laughed,
tilted her head,
pressed me deeper into her world,
and let me drown.*

*She let me lead, let me whisper,
let me play the part of the man in control,
but when the morning light kissed her skin,
when she stretched like a queen in silk sheets,
I knew
I had never been in charge.*

I Let Her Ruin Me

*She had me. Completely. No fight, no pride, no name.
Just skin on skin, breath on breath,
me slipping deeper into the space between her thighs,
where time slowed, and reason drowned.*

*I was a man before her, sharp, calculated, untouchable.
But in her hands, I unraveled,
bones turning to smoke,
control bleeding out in moans I swore I'd never make.*

*She rode me like she owned me,
like she knew my undoing was stitched in the way she moved,
hips rolling, nails dragging, mouth curved in something wicked,
a slow, torturous rhythm that made me beg
and I swore I never begged.*

*"You're mine," she whispered, tongue tracing the shell of my ear,
and I nodded helpless, breathless, already lost.
My fingers dug into her skin, desperate to hold on,
but she was slipping, shifting, leading me deeper,
until there was no edge, no floor, no escape.*

*I wanted to stop just for a second,
just long enough to remember who I was before her,
but she wouldn't let me.
Her body tightened, her lips found my pulse,
and just like that, I shattered
a man broken open, devoured whole.*

*And when it was over, when she lay back,
satisfied, smug, victorious,
I realized
I had never stood a chance*

Love Ain't The Word

*Could I love a woman made of smoke and sin?
A woman who moved like temptation itself,
who kissed me deep enough to make me forget my name,
then left my sheets cold by morning?*

*I told myself no
that I was just lost in the spell of her skin,
that it was lust, not love,
that I wasn't one of those fools who thought
a whore could be a house.*

*But then she smiled,
and something in me cracked.*

*She had me questioning
Was I chasing her because I wanted her?
Or because I needed to prove
that she could be mine alone?*

*But love ain't the word for a woman
who never belonged to one man,
who let me hold her close,
whisper promises she never intended to keep,
then slipped away like a thief in the dark.*

*She swore she was mine,
but she moaned another man's name in the same breath,
came home smelling like cologne I didn't wear,
with lips swollen from kisses I didn't give her.*

*And still, I stayed.
Still, I let her crawl back into my bed,
whisper lies into my skin,
make me forget for a night, at least
that she was never mine to begin with.*

Could I love a woman like that?

*I looked at her, eyes full of apologies
I couldn't stomach anymore,
and I finally knew the answer.*

*No.
I never loved her.
I just hated losing.*

I Left, But She Never Did

*I told myself this was it.
No more late-night calls, no more lips that lied,
no more pretending she could ever be something
other than a wound I kept pressing just to feel something.*

*She looked at me, smirking curling like she knew better.
Like she'd heard this before.*

*"You'll be back," she whispered, stretching lazy in my sheets,
like she was permanent, like she was home.*

*But I wasn't losing.
Not this time.*

*Because the only place I was losing
was in having her
in the way her body made me forget
that love wasn't supposed to feel like war,
that real peace didn't taste like regret in the morning.*

*I pulled my shirt over my head,
stepped back as she sat up, hair wild,
eyes still glowing with the ghosts of men
who all thought they'd be the one to tame her.*

*"I'm not them," I said, more to myself than to her.
I had to believe it.*

*She just smiled, slow, knowing, stretching like she had all the time
in the world.*

*"You never were," she said.
And that scared me more than losing her.*

I walked out.

Didn't look back.

*But even after I was gone,
after her scent faded from my sheets,
after my phone stayed silent at 2 a.m.,
she stayed
tucked in the cracks of my thoughts,
whispering in the spaces between sleep and waking.*

I left her.

But I don't think she really left me.

III. The Cracks in the Throne

What If I Stayed?

*What if I stayed
let her love settle into the cracks
instead of running before it could reach me?
What if I met her halfway,
instead of watching her walk the whole distance alone?*

*She was steady hands on my restless skin,
a warmth I only learned to miss in the cold.
She was Sunday morning peace,
but I was Saturday night sin,
too wild, too selfish, too sure I had time.*

*I told myself she was too good,
too patient, too soft for a man like me.
But the truth?
She wasn't too much
I was just too little.*

*She wanted a builder,
but I only knew how to break.
She prayed for me,
and I laughed at her faith,
never knowing one day I'd kneel,
asking God why He sent me love
before I was man enough to hold it.*

*And now, some nights,
when my bed is too wide,
when silence hums where her voice used to be,
I wonder*

*What if I stayed?
Would I have been enough,
or just learned new ways to lose her?*

She Knew My Mother's Name

*She sat across from my mother,
laughing like they shared a secret
that had nothing to do with me.
Like they had history,
like they had plans
like she wasn't just passing through.*

*She knew my mother's name.
Not just the name the world called her,
but the name she carried before the weight of life
curved her spine and thinned her voice.
She said it softly, like she belonged there.
Like she could love what made me
before I even knew how to love myself.*

*She folded into my family like she was born for it,
like she had always been meant to be
the one to fix what I never had the hands for.
And I let her. I let her love my mother,
my sisters, my past
everything but me.*

*Because love like that is heavy.
Because I didn't want to owe her anything
when I finally ran.*

*And when I did
when I left her standing in that kitchen,
still stirring, still hoping, still waiting
I told myself it was mercy.*

*Better to hurt her now
than let her think I could ever be
the man she deserved.*

*But years later, I saw her again.
She didn't look at me the same.
She didn't smile.
She didn't speak.
And for the first time in my life,
I felt like a stranger in my story.*

*She knew my mother's name.
And now
I'm the one she forgot.*

The One I Could've Built With

Man... I am thinking.

Like, really thinking.

Like, sitting in my car staring at the steering wheel type thinking.

I had 'em all

the ones that smelled like vanilla and bad decisions,

the ones that only hit my phone after midnight,

the ones that left their earrings on purpose

like they were marking territory.

Had 'em laughing, had 'em screaming,

had 'em swearing I was the best they ever had.

Had 'em for a night, maybe two.

Had 'em, then forgot 'em.

But her?

Man... she is different.

She knew my favorite meal without asking.

Knew when I was lying before I said a word.

Knew how to be quiet when I ain't feel like talking,

and knew how to talk when I didn't feel like listening.

She knew me.

And I don't know what to do with that.

I fumbled. Hard.

*Treated her like all the rest
when she was nothing like them.*

And the crazy part?

She never hated me for it.

Just looked at me one day, real soft, and said,

“You ain’t ready for me, are you?”

And I wasn’t.

So now she is gone.

*Probably laughing in some other man’s passenger seat,
probably learning his favorite meal,
probably knowing him better than he knows himself.*

And me?

I got hoes.

But I don’t get her.

She Prayed For Me

*She used to hold my hands like they was something holy,
like maybe if she held tight enough,
some of that goodness in her would sink into my skin.
Like she could love me into being a better man.*

I remember one night,

I was laid up in her lap, half-listening,

*half-tracing circles on her thigh.
She sighed, real soft,
ran her fingers through my hair,
and whispered, "I pray for you, you know?"*

*I laughed.
Laughed like she just told me some dumb joke.
Like I wasn't worth praying for.
Like I ain't need saving.*

*But she just smiled.
Didn't argue. Didn't preach.
Just kissed my forehead and kept loving me anyway.*

*And that?
That hurt more than if she woulda curse me out.
More than if she slammed the door in my face.
More than if she woulda told me I wasn't shit and never would
be.*

*Because deep down,
I knew she saw something in me I couldn't see in myself.
And I hated her for that.*

*Hated how she made me feel like I was worth something.
Hated how she looked at me like I was more than the sum of my
sins.*

Hated how she prayed for a man who had no plans of being saved.

I think about that sometimes.

Wonder if she still prays for me.

Wonder if she prays for him now instead.

Wonder if he deserves it more.

She Deserved a Husband, Not a Hobby

I tried to make her leave.

Gave her every reason, every excuse.

*Said the meanest shit I could think of,
watched the words hit her like bricks,
but she just blinked, wiped her face,
and said, "**That's all you got?**"*

I ain't never met a woman so stubborn.

*She saw the wreckage and still stayed,
like love made her immune to the smoke,
like she ain't mind suffocating
if it meant she could save me.*

I came home drunk,

*perfume on my shirt that wasn't hers,
lips swollen from kisses she ain't give me,
and she still made me coffee in the morning.*

*Sat across from me, stirring her tea,
not saying a word.*

*That silence killed me.
Worse than screaming.
Worse than a slap.
Worse than leaving.*

*Because I knew she was waiting.
Waiting for me to be better.
Waiting for me to catch up to the love
she was so damn ready to give me.*

*And I?
I was busy setting fire to everything,
just to see if she'd stay in the flames.*

*She did.
And I hated her for that too.*

One Day, She'll Be Loved

*I hope he knows to bring her lilies.
Not roses she always said roses were lazy,
the bare minimum of romance.
But lilies?
She loved how they opened slow,*

*like they were stretching awake,
like love should be patient, unhurried.*

*I hope he listens when she talks about true crime,
how her favorite killer was the one
who never got caught.
Not 'cause she liked what he did,
but because she admired a mystery,
the way a mind could be dark and still fascinating.
She used to say, **"Even monsters need love."**
And maybe that's why she stayed so long.*

*I hope he calls her at lunch,
just to hear her voice.
Texts her **"made it home safe?"**
even when she forgets to check in.
Because she'll act like she don't need that,
but she does.*

*I hope he kisses her wrists.
I never did.
Never thought to.
Didn't realize that's where she carried her stress,
where she rubbed when she was thinking,
where her pulse beat quickly when she was happy.*

*I hope he makes her tea,
with just enough honey,*

not too much milk.

She likes it warm, not scalding.

I always made it too hot,

made her wait before she could enjoy it.

Maybe that was a metaphor.

I hope he loves her in a way

that don't feel like work,

like trying,

like forcing himself to be someone he ain't.

I hope it's easy for him.

Effortless.

The way it should've been for me.

I hope she forgets how I made her feel.

And I hate that I hope that.

But I do.

The Last Time I Saw Her

She stood in the doorway, wearing my favorite color.

Not that she knew that.

Or maybe she did.

She always paid attention when I wasn't looking.

I wanted to say something,

but words felt like knives in my throat,

sharp with regret, heavy with truth.

So I just stared.

She looked at me like she already knew.

*Like she'd read the ending of this story
long before I had the courage to turn the page.*

"I love you," she said, voice steady, like a fact.

*Like gravity. Like breath. Like something
I should have believed, but never did.*

I closed my eyes.

*Because when I looked at her,
I saw everything I could've been
a man worth keeping.*

A man who stayed.

*A man who wasn't too afraid
try, trust, be good.*

But I ain't him.

I never was.

*So I reached for a lie,
something to make this easier,
something to turn her softness into stone,
to make her hate me enough
to stop loving me.*

"You deserve better."

It was the kindest way I knew how to leave.

She laughed, but it wasn't funny.

*"You think I don't know that?" she said,
shaking her head like I was the biggest fool alive.*

And I was.

*Because in that moment,
I realized she had never been the one
who needed convincing.*

I was.

I wanted to ask her to wait.

*To save me a seat at the table of her love,
Believe in me even when I couldn't.*

But I knew better.

*She had spent too many nights
praying for a man who would never arrive.*

So I let her go.

*Because I knew she'd spend the rest of her life
waiting for a man who believed in himself.
And I wasn't sure I ever would.*

IV. The Fall of Solomon

She Called Me Out

*I fed her lines like scripture, smooth as silk and twice as tight,
Told her she was something different, something rare, something
right.*

*But she just laughed low and knowing like she'd heard it all
before,
Sipped her drink, crossed her legs, left me stranded at the door.*

*"You talk too much," she finally said, eyes like knives against my
chest.*

*"Bet you tell them all they're special, just to see which one says
yes."*

*I smirked, like I had answers, but my tongue was tied in chains,
Because she wasn't just **listening** she was studying the game.*

*I leaned in close, played my role, let my fingers brush her sleeve,
But she didn't melt, didn't blush, didn't give me room to breathe.
She just held her ground, too calm, too cool, too unimpressed,
And I felt something strange creep in a quiet kind of stress.*

*She called me out without a whisper, without even raising hell,
Like a judge who'd read my verdict long before the hammer fell.
Every trick, every tale, every polished little line,
She disassembled me with ease piece by piece, lie by lie.*

*And as I watched her walk away, hips swaying, heels clicking,
I swore I'd let her go, but something deep kept itching.
Because she was the first to **see me**, to pull apart my show,
And for the first damn time in my life **I didn't want to go.***

No Games, Just Mirrors

*She wasn't a queen, a muse, a prize
She wasn't impressed with rehearsed goodbyes.
Didn't chase, didn't flinch, didn't play pretend,
Didn't smile just to let me win.*

*She didn't lean in when I spoke real low,
Didn't gasp when I threatened to go.
Didn't beg for my love, didn't fawn at my name,
Didn't need my rules. **She wasn't in the game.***

*She held up a mirror, clear and cold,
And I saw myself in the way she told
The half-truth smiles, the hollow plans,
The man was a boy, with empty hands.*

*She said, **"You're used to being worshipped, but I ain't got the time."***

*She said, **"You love yourself so much, you never learned to love right."***

*I watched her, stunned, no script, no cue,
No clever escape, no line to use.*

*I reached for her wrist she slipped away,
Left me standing in my own decay.
No text, no call, no second chance,
No slow unraveling, no final glance.*

*And now I see her in reflections dim,
In car windows, in barroom hymns.
She didn't stay, she didn't weep,
Didn't haunt my nights **but she owns my sleep.***

Her Eyes Were My Confession

*She ain't have to yell, she ain't have to beg,
Ain't throw no glass, ain't call me fake.
Just sat there, staring, real damn still,
Like she already knew but wanted me to spill.*

*And I swear to God, I almost did.
Almost cracked, almost slid,
Almost let the weight of every lie
Come crashing out in real time.*

But I ain't built like that.

Nah.

I play it cool.

Play it sharp.

Give a half-smile, shrug, lean back in the dark.

*Say some shit like, "You trippin', girl,"
Try to laugh, try to twist her world.*

But she didn't laugh.

Didn't even blink.

*Just kept looking at me like she could **smell the stink**
Of every slick word, every empty vow,
Every time I left and came back somehow.*

I felt naked.

And not the good kind.

Not the slow, soft, whispered-moan kind.

*The kind where you cold, under bright white lights,
Where somebody bigger than you just read you your rights.*

She wasn't arguing.

She wasn't mad.

*Just **disappointed** and somehow, that hurt more than that.*

And I sat there, stomach tight,

Mind running through every fight,

Every promise I ain't keep,

Every lie I put to sleep.

I should've apologized.

Should've grabbed her hand.

Should've told her what I was,

Tried to make her understand.

But I ain't say shit.

Just let the silence stretch and bend,

Until she sighed, shook her head

*And let me lose her **like a man.***

"You're Not Solomon"

"Damn, you really think of him, huh?"

She said it real calm, real easy,

like she wasn't about to cut me open

with a sentence that sharp.

"All that talk about wisdom, about game,

but you ain't wise, baby.

You're just scared."

I laughed 'cause what else was I supposed to do?

She ain't blink, though.

Ain't smile. Ain't flinch.

Just sat there, one leg crossed over the other,

fingers tapping slow on the rim of her glass,

watching me squirm like she had all the time in the world.

"You ever ask yourself why you move like this?

Why you collect women like trophies,

*but never keep one long enough to gather dust?"**

*I sip my drink, clear my throat,
say some slick shit about how I ain't meant to be caged,
how kings don't kneel, how love ain't in my blood.*

She smirks.

Not the kind you wanna see.

Not the soft, flirty kind.

The kind that says, "I feel sorry for you."

"See, Solomon had a kingdom."

She leans forward now, elbows on the table.

"You got a roster."

Ouch.

"Solomon had wisdom."

She tilts her head.

"You got excuses."

Damn.

"Solomon fell 'cause he let his demons in."

She leans back, arms crossed now.

"You are already living with yours."

I should leave.

Should laugh.

Should brush this shit off,

*text one of my girls,
remind myself I still have options.*

*But my hands are still on the table.
Still empty.
And for the first time in a long time,
I ain't got a single word to say.*

"Why Are You Like This?"

*She doesn't yell.
She doesn't beg.
She doesn't even sound mad.*

Just tired.

*Like she already knew the answer,
like she already knew me better than I ever did.*

"You break everything you touch."

*She says it soft,
watching me, waiting,
like I got some grand explanation,
some excuse that'll make it all make sense.*

I don't.

*I sip my drink slow,
pretend it don't sting,
pretend I ain't shifting in my seat.*

*"You love what's easy, what don't ask for too much."
She leans back, head tilted, studying me.
"You want worship, not love. You want control, not closeness.
And when you get something real?"
She exhales, eyes cutting straight through me.
"You set it on fire, just to watch it burn."*

*I laugh, but it's hollow.
Shake my head, try to play it cool.
"Man, you overthinking it."*

*"Am I?"
She don't flinch.
She don't blink.
She don't move.*

*And I swear, for the first time,
I feel naked.
Like she peeled me open with her bare hands
and laid every ugly piece of me on the table.
"You ever even ask yourself why?" she says.
"Or is it just easier not to?"*

The ice in my glass clinks.

The room feels too quiet.

I swallow hard.

Look away.

Wish I had a lie ready.

Wish I had the nerve to say,

"I don't know."

But we both know the truth.

I ain't ready to say it.

And she ain't waiting for me to figure it out.

"The Woman Who Didn't Want Me"

She moved like moonlight slipping through fingers,

soft, distant never mine to hold.

She kissed me without sinking,

lips like a whisper, touch like a ghost,

and when she pulled away,

I swear she took something with her.

I been loved, been worshipped,

been the sun they circled 'round.

But she?

She stayed in her own orbit,

eyes too knowing, smile too sharp,

never once mistaking me for a god.

*"You ain't Solomon, baby,"
she hummed,
tracing my jaw with the tip of her nail.
"You just a man who likes the sound of his own name."*

*She said it smooth,
like it wasn't a wound she just opened.
Like she ain't just put a mirror in front of me
and dare me to look.*

*I tried to unravel her,
press my fingers into her silence,
pull her into the gravity of my hands.
But she never wavered.
Never lost herself.
She let me in without giving me shit to hold onto.*

*And when she left,
she ain't cry, ain't beg, ain't look back.
She just gathered her perfume,
her red nails, her steady voice
and vanished like she was never there.*

*Now, my phone stays dry.
No missed calls, no "I miss you" texts.
And me?
I keep telling myself I ain't thinking about her.*

That she was just another one.

That she didn't win.

But some nights,

when the air is thick and my bed feels too big,

I wonder

Was she even mine to lose?

Or was I just another story

she walked away from,

without ever needing to know the ending?

"She'll Forget Me, But I Won't Forget Her"

She was the only one who never knelt.

Never folded.

Never gave me that look the one that said,

"You could ruin me, and I'd thank you for it."

No.

She was the storm I couldn't sail through.

The door I couldn't kick open.

The silence that swallowed my name whole

and spat it back out like it never mattered.

I should've seen it coming.

She studied me like a bad habit

she was never addicted to.

*Watched me spin my web,
watched other women get caught,
and just stepped over the bodies.
Unmoved. Unimpressed.*

*"You want me 'cause I don't want you," she said,
arms crossed, weight on one hip,
mouth curled up like she knew something I didn't.
And maybe she did.
Maybe she saw the boy under the crown,
the cracks in the gold,
the hollowness I kept dressing up in silk and smoke.*

*I called her a challenge.
She called me a waste of time.*

*And when she left, she ain't leave a mark.
No lipstick on my mirror;
no earrings under my bed,
no scent in my sheets.
Just a gap in the air,
a space that still hums with her absence.*

*And me?
I keep reaching for ghosts.
Keep talking to echoes.
Keep looking for her in every woman who stays too long,*

*waiting for one to be as cruel, as clean,
as devastating.*

But I know better.

They don't make them like her twice.

And she?

*She's somewhere forgetting me
the way I wish I could forget her.*

V. The Ruins of Pride

We Weren't Innocent

*We weren't no soft love, no Sunday morning sweetness,
no "good morning, my love" type of shit.*

*Nah. We was streetlights humming at 3AM,
we was hands around throats just to feel something.*

*We was "baby, I love you" through clenched teeth,
right before the next war started.*

I fucked up first.

Yeah, I did it. Ain't no excuses.

She cried, but she ain't leave.

*Just tucked it in her back pocket like a blade,
waitin' on the right time to slide it across my throat.*

*And I? I thought we was good.
Thought we made it through.
Thought the blood dried and the past was buried.
Til she said she needed space.
Some air. Some time.
A fuckin' break.*

*And I, dumb as hell,
kissed her forehead, said "yeah, okay."
Told her I'd wait.
Like a fool. Like a simp.
Like I ain't know what "a break" really meant.*

*Two weeks later, she came back,
eyes all swollen, voice all soft.
Told me she "got caught up,"
Told me she "didn't mean to,"
Told me it "just happened."
Like he tripped and fell dick-first into her.*

*And my heart?
Shit, my heart ain't break
it cracked,
it snapped,
it crumbled like a house made of all the lies we told each other.*

*See, I could fuck half the city,
but she was supposed to be different.
She was supposed to cry and claw at my chest,
not spread her legs for the first smooth talkin' motherfucker
who told her she deserved better.*

*And now, when I look at her?
All I see is him.
His hands on her hips.
His lips on her collarbone.
His fuckin' voice laughin' in the dark
a ghost in my own goddamn bed.*

*So I went on a warpath.
Drowned in bodies that didn't smell like her.
Tried to fuck the taste of her out my mouth.
But no matter how many women I left breathless,
I still woke up choking on her name.*

*And she?
She still looks at me with those big, wet eyes,
like I was supposed to understand.
Like I was supposed to forgive.*

*But love ain't built like that.
Not ours.
Ours was war.
And war don't end in peace.*

“The Night I Left Her Crying”

Her name popped up.

*New number. Same ghost.
Said she just wanted to talk,
like words could patch a slit throat.
Like I ain't been bleedin' out for days,
wonderin' how she slept so sound
after rippin' me open.*

“I didn't mean to hurt you.”

*That's the first thing she said,
like that shit ever mattered.
Like it was the intention,
not the action, that left me
punchin' holes through my own reflection.*

*And then she added more.
More details I ain't ask for.
More reasons to hate her.
More bricks to the chest.*

“It wasn't just once.”

“We weren't even drunk.”

“He kissed me first but, I mean, I let him.”

“I cried after... does that count for something?”

*Man, I sat there, phone burnin' in my palm,
wonderin' what the **fuck** I did in a past life
to deserve this kinda punishment.*

I ain't cheat.

Ain't even think about it.

*But somehow, I woke up blocked on everything
IG, Twitter, my own goddamn email.*

Even the Bible app, bruh.

Like, she ain't want me near God neither.

Like, damn, I can't even read Proverbs in peace?

*And now she sittin' here,
talkin' all slow, all sorry,
sayin' she miss me.
Sayin' she made a mistake.
Sayin' she been prayin' on it,
like I'm some test God put in her path
just to see if she could stay faithful.*

And I almost caved.

Almost believed it.

*Almost let her weave her way back in,
curl up in the place where my trust used to be.*

*But then I heard his voice in my head.
The one she swore didn't mean shit.
The one she let whisper against her neck.*

*The one she chose
when she said she needed space.*

*So I inhaled slow,
let the silence stretch long,
then gave her the only truth I had left*

“I hope he was worth it.”

*And just like that, I heard it.
That sharp little breath.
That stutter in her throat.
That exact second she realized
she lost something she couldn't get back.*

*And me?
I just walked away,
left her sittin' in the wreckage she built,
tears spillin' where my love used to be.*

“She Said She'd Get Me Back”

*I should've known.
Should've caught it in the way she smiled,
all teeth, no warmth,
like she was already making a plan,
already setting the stage.*

“I’ll get you back.”

*She said it soft,
like a promise,
like a prayer,
like a curse.*

And I laughed.

*Because what could she do to me
that I ain’t already survived?
I thought I was untouchable.
Unmovable.
Above all that.*

*But see, vengeance ain’t always loud.
Sometimes, it’s whispered between sheets
that don’t belong to you.
Sometimes, it’s written in lipstick
on a mirror you ain’t ever looked in.
Sometimes, it’s soft moans in a room
where your name ain’t never been spoken.*

*And that’s how she did it.
Not with fists, not with fire,
but with silence,
with another man’s weight between her thighs,
with a smirk when she finally told me,*

*like she had been waiting to see my face
crack open like an egg.*

*And I tried
Tried to act unbothered,
tried to smirk back,
tried to laugh like it ain't burn.*

*But she saw it.
She saw the way my jaw tensed,
the way my hands curled into fists.
She saw the moment I **felt it.***

*And she leaned in,
breath hot against my ear,
whispered, "**Now we're even.**"*

*And I swear to God,
it wasn't even the cheating that broke me
it was the way she walked away,
heels clicking against the pavement,
like she had just won a game
I ain't even know I was playing.*

“Was He Better Than Me?”

I ain't even mean to ask.

Swear to God, I didn't.

*But that question been crawlin' up my throat
since the night she confessed.*

Was he better than me?

Did he kiss you like he was starvin'?

*Did he press his weight against you,
make you shiver when he whispered,
make you beg when he pulled away?*

*Did he touch you like I used to,
or did he fumble,
all clumsy hands and dead weight?*

Did you call him baby?

Did you call him mine?

*Did you say his name
the way you used to say mine
like a promise,
like a prayer,
like I was the only thing
you ever believed in?*

Tell me.

Did he make you feel safe,

or just satisfied?

Did he make you feel loved,

or just needed?

Did you close your eyes and see me,

or did he carve a whole new home inside you,

one I could never enter again?

And when it was over

when you laid there in the after,

his breath still heavy on your skin

did you feel whole?

Or did you feel hollow,

like all he did was stretch out the space

where I used to live?

Was he better than me?

I almost ain't wanna hear the answer.

Almost ain't wanna know.

But she looked at me,

eyes glistening,

lips parting,

words forming

And I saw it.

The hesitation.

The regret.

*The guilt sinking in
just a second too late.*

*And that's when I knew.
That's when I laughed.*

*Because it didn't even matter, did it?
Better or worse,
she still lost me.*

I Tried to Love Her Again

*I tried. I swear I did.
Sat across from her at some dimly lit spot,
watching her stir her drink like she was mixing up lies,
watching the candlelight flicker in her eyes,
wondering if it reflected back the man she let inside her.*

*I sipped slow,
let the burn settle under my tongue
before I opened my mouth and ruined everything.
Tried to see her how I used to
soft, sweet, something worth staying for.
Tried to forget the weight of his name in her mouth.*

*But I couldn't.
All I saw was **him**.*

*Like he left fingerprints on her skin I could never scrub off,
like he rewrote her body in a language I never learned.*

She smiled like nothing happened.

*Like I ain't seen her knees bruised from kneeling for another
man.*

*Like I ain't hear her breath hitch when I pulled her close,
like she had to remind herself that **I was him before him.***

*And I wanted to love her, I really did
but only in the way a king loves his crown,
only in the way a man loves a secret he never meant to tell.*

Because the truth?

I ain't love her.

*I loved **having** her.*

Loved the way she reached for me like I was her god.

*Loved how she folded,
how she made me feel like I was the only thing worth breaking
for.*

*And maybe that's why I kept her around,
why I let her crawl back into my bed,
why I kissed her slow and deep
like I was searching for the part of me she swallowed.*

But love?

No, love was never in it.

Just possession. Just habit. Just lust dressed up in borrowed feelings.

Just me playing victim, pretending like I ain't ruin her first.

Pretending like I wasn't the one who set this whole thing on fire.

She wanted redemption.

I just wanted revenge.

And that's why, when she whispered, "I miss you."

I pulled her closer,

kissed her like I meant it,

ran my hands over every inch of her,

and left her there

naked, breathless, undone

just so she could feel what it was like

to lose something you thought was yours.

"My Revenge Was Sleeping With Her Ghost"

I traced her name in the sweat of another woman's back,

watched it disappear when she rolled over,

just like she did.

I reached for someone new,

but my hands only found echoes,

bodies shaped like distractions,

moaning sounds that never quite matched the melody I

remembered.

*I kissed lips that weren't hers,
tasted liquor instead of love,
called them baby because their names felt foreign on my tongue,
because every damn one of them
was just an understudy in a play she wrote.*

And they let me.

Let me pretend.

*Let me **fuck her through them**,
like my body could summon her ghost,
like every thrust was a séance,
like if I went deep enough,
I'd hit the place where she still loved me.*

But I never did.

Never could.

*Because she wasn't in the way their fingers traced my ribs,
or the way they arched, or sighed, or begged.
She wasn't in the moans,
or the morning after,
or the slow drag of a cigarette at 3 AM
when the sheets still smelled like someone I didn't care about.*

She was in the silence.

*In the space between one woman leaving
and the next one walking through my door.*

*In the way I stopped saying I love you
because I could still hear her laughing in my head.*

*She was in the mirror,
in the guilt stitched into my reflection,
in the way I sat in my own filth,
surrounded by all these bodies
but somehow still alone.*

*I thought I could bury her in flesh,
drown her in perfume and sweat,
forget her in the heat of a stranger's mouth.*

*But all I did was resurrect her.
Again, and again, and again.*

*Because no matter how many women I took to bed,
the only one I ever really fucked
was her ghost*

We Weren't Supposed To

*She smelled like a song I ain't never heard,
but somehow knew every damn word.
A melody thick with midnight and Moët,
skin caramel-dipped, glowing like sin done blessed her.*

*She moved slow, like she owned time,
like the world was just a room she was passing through.
Gold hoops swayed like whispers 'round her neck,
and her dress red, tight,
like a secret too loud to keep.*

*I told myself I was just looking.
Just admiring God's audacity.
But then she turned
eyes dark, heavy-lashed, the kind that tell you
"Come closer," even when they mean "Run."*

And I came.

*She said her name like it wasn't dangerous,
like it wouldn't taste like regret in the morning.
Voice rich, dipped in something sweet,
with just enough edge to cut through my caution.
Laughed low, touched my wrist,
leaned in like she had something holy to confess
or something filthy.*

*I swear I ain't hear the DJ switch the track,
'cause the only rhythm I felt was her breathing,
the way it synced with mine,
like our bodies had history our minds ain't yet remember.*

We danced.

*No she danced, and I followed,
hands hovering, then gripping, then lost.
My fingers traced the line between good man and fool,
and by the time she pulled me closer,
I ain't care where I landed.*

*"You always this smooth?" she asked,
lips teasing the rim of her glass,
eyes teasing me worse.*

"Only when I'm inspired."

*She smirked, slow. Knowing.
Ran her nails down my arm,
sent a shiver straight through my sense.
Told me she liked the way I talked,
the way I looked at her,
like she was the last temptation.*

And maybe she was.

*I ain't ask about a man.
Ain't check for a ring.
Ain't think past the neon lights and the way her body fit against
mine.
I was too lost in the lie we both was telling,*

*too drunk off the thought that she was mine,
even if just for a song.*

*But when she kissed me,
pressed lips soft and slow, like she was taking her time,
like she was memorizing me for later
that's when I knew.*

*Not by the way she tasted,
but by the way she trembled,
like guilt had her by the throat.*

*That's when I knew
we weren't supposed to.*

Karma Kissed Me Back

*I wake up smelling her perfume in rooms she ain't never been in.
Vanilla and violets, thick like a whispered warning,
clinging to my sheets, my skin, my sins.
I shower twice but she don't rinse off
she lingers, soaks into my marrow like she got a key to my body.*

*I tell myself it's nothing.
Just another night.
Just another woman.
But lies don't hold weight against a soul tie,
and I feel her in places prayers don't reach.*

She left her laugh in my throat.

Left her breath on my neck.

Left her name in my mouth like a prayer I wasn't supposed to say.

Now, every woman I touch feels like a mistake,

like they borrowing a body that don't belong to them.

Like I'm renting my skin out to ghosts.

I close my eyes,

but behind the lids, I see her

bare-shouldered and bitten-lipped,

moaning secrets into my palms,

fingernails digging scripture into my back.

*I swear I hear her whisper, "**More.**"*

And I give.

And I give.

And I give.

Then she leaves,

slipping through my fingers like a promise she never meant to keep.

And I swear I can hear the door lock behind her.

But she don't be gone.

Not really.

She stay in the way I move.

Stay in the way my bed feel too big when I sleep alone.

Stay in the way I flinch when my phone ring,

*half-expecting it to be her, half-hoping it ain't.
Stay in the way my hands still remember her hips,
like they were sculpted just to hold them.*

I see her man once.

At a gas station, buying her favorite flowers.

White lilies.

Innocence.

A lie in a bouquet.

I wonder if he smells me on her the way I smell her on me.

*Wonder if he kisses her slow,
if she closes her eyes and pictures my lips instead.*

I tell myself I ain't care.

*Tell myself she was just a body,
a moment,
a mistake.*

But my heart beat different now.

Like it's been tampered with.

Like somebody else got their hands on the controls.

They say soul ties don't break easy.

I'm startin' to think they don't break at all.

"The Prayer I Can't Say"

I tried to pray last night.

*Sat on the edge of my bed, hands folded,
like maybe if I gripped them tight enough,
I could press the sin out my skin.*

But my tongue wouldn't move.

Wouldn't form the words.

*Wouldn't dare speak God's name
with her still on my breath.*

I know He saw me.

Not just that night all of them.

*Saw me trace fire on skin that wasn't mine,
saw me press my lips to stolen fruit,
saw me swallow guilt like it was communion wine.
And still come back for more.*

I know better.

Mama raised me better.

*Grandma prayed over me like I was a house to be blessed,
but I keep kicking the doors open,
inviting ghosts in,
letting demons make themselves comfortable.*

*And now, my own name feels foreign in my mouth,
like I ain't even the same man who grew up in Sunday school,*

*who used to believe in mercy,
who used to believe in himself.*

*So I sit in the dark.
Hands still locked,
lips still sealed,
with a prayer I can't say
and a God who already knows.*

"The Guilt Feels Like Her Perfume"

*It lingers.
Sticks to my skin like sweat after sin,
like cigarette smoke in a Sunday suit,
like the echo of a name I shouldn't have whispered.*

*Her perfume jasmine, vanilla, and something dangerous,
something that smelled like promises neither of us could keep.
I swear I still catch it in empty rooms,
like the guilt found a way to haunt me.*

*I shower three times.
Scrub my hands raw, like I'm trying to wash off the crime,
but the scent won't leave.
Neither will the weight.*

*Her laugh sweet and wrong at the same time.
Her touch warm, then burning, then ice.*

*The way she looked at me like a woman who already knew regret
but didn't care enough to stop.*

I should have stopped.

Should have seen the gold band before I saw her lips.

Should have asked her name before I memorized her body.

Should have left before she whispered,

"No one has to know."

But someone always knows.

Even if it's just me.

Even if it's just God.

*Even if it's just the walls in my bedroom,
soaked in the scent of her sins and mine.*

*And now, every time I breathe in,
it smells like jasmine, vanilla
and a mistake that won't fade.*

"I Knew Better"

The sheets still smell like thunder.

*Like rain-soaked pavement and something electric,
something that crackled between us before the storm ever hit.*

I should've left when the sky warned me,

*when the air got thick,
when the wind told me her name didn't belong in my mouth.*

But I stayed.

*Let her hands become lightning
striking, searing, setting fire to my good sense.*

*Let her lips taste like a crime scene
red, wet, begging to be silenced.*

*Let her body be the altar where I laid my conscience down
and walked away baptized in sweat and secrets.*

I knew better.

*Knew the way her voice dropped when she said, "Don't ask me
that,"*

*knew the way she flinched when my phone rang at midnight,
knew the way her nails dug too deep,
like she was trying to hold onto something slipping from her
grasp.*

I knew better,

*but I still traced her back home in the scent of hotel linen.
Still let her name sit heavy in my chest like an unpaid debt.
Still caught myself watching the door,
waiting for karma to walk in wearing her husband's face.*

And now, every room is too small.

Every silence is too loud.

Every touch feels borrowed, stolen, not mine to keep.

*I knew better,
but knowing ain't ever stopped a man from burning
when he's already too close to the flame.*

We Never Spoke Again

*I tell myself it was just a night.
Just skin on skin, just hands that shouldn't have wandered,
just lips that knew better and didn't care.
But I feel her still.
Like a bad habit, like a song I hate but can't stop humming.*

*She left first.
Didn't fumble for excuses, didn't linger.
Just slipped her ring back on,
checked her reflection like she was fixing a smudge,
and walked out
like I was nothing but a moment to be cleaned up.*

*I stared at the door,
waiting for it to knock, waiting for her to forget something,
waiting for her to come back and say what?
That she wanted me? That she regretted it?
That she felt it too?*

She didn't.

And I didn't call.

Didn't text.

Didn't reach for a name I wasn't supposed to have.

A week passed. Then two.

Then a month.

And the silence started growing teeth.

I'd hear a laugh that sounded like hers and my stomach would drop.

I'd see a red dress and taste regret.

She became a shadow I couldn't shake.

A question I couldn't answer.

A sin that never settled right in my chest.

And we never spoke again.

*Not because we didn't want to
but because we knew if we did,
we'd do it all over again.*

Her Husband Didn't

He never knew.

*Never caught the scent of sin on her skin,
never traced the fingerprints I left like ink.*

*He held her hand, kissed her cheek,
while I sat in the dark with a mouth full of secrets.*

*She laid beside him, spine straight,
breathing even, lips stitched tight.
Did she dream of me?
Did she flinch when he whispered her name,
when his fingers grazed where mine had been?*

*I wonder if he noticed the way she blinked too slow,
the way her smile had a second of delay,
like her heart was still catching up,
like she was pulling herself back from another man's arms.*

*I saw them once together.
A picture-perfect frame of vows unshaken.
He laughed, deep and easy,
like he had no reason to fear the storm sitting right beside him.*

*I almost pitied him.
A king without a crown, a fool with a queen he couldn't see.
A man who prayed at night while his wife was on her knees for
me.*

*But I wasn't bold.
I wasn't brave.
I was just a ghost in their house, a stain on her soul,
a crack in the vows that never quite broke
but bent, bent, bent.*

And her husband?

Her husband didn't know.

Didn't see.

*Didn't wake up in the middle of the night
to a body that wasn't fully his.*

Didn't hear my name in the silence.

Didn't feel my touch in the spaces between.

*Didn't realize he was sharing a love
that no longer belonged to him.*

Her Silence Is My Sentence

You ever been punished without a word?

*Not a slam, not a scream, not a "you ain't shit"
just silence, clean like a cut from a blade too sharp to feel.*

She ain't block me outta anger.

She just...

stopped seein' me.

Ain't that some cold shit?

*I tell myself she doin' it to teach me a lesson,
so I can pretend I still matter in the story.*

*Like maybe,
just maybe,
she'll break the silence when she ready to forgive me.*

*'Cause ain't no way she just left,
like I was never somethin' she cared to lose.*

Nah.

*She gotta be playin' chess,
treatin' me like a pawn to prove a point.
I mean,
why else would a woman like her walk away
from a man like me?*

...Right?

*But I know the truth, deep down where I don't visit often.
She ain't punishin' me.
She just found peace,
and a man like me got no place in it.*

*And that?
That's worse than any cuss out,
any slap,
any tear-filled goodbye.
That's a sentence with no parole.*

*Ain't no breakin' silence
when she don't even hear me no more.*

She Loved Me, Then She Left Me

*See, baby girl moved like jazz
smooth, effortless, like she knew the rhythm before I even heard
the beat.*

*She'd laugh, low and smoky,
like she already knew the punchline to a joke I ain't tell yet.
I thought I had her,
thought my name was carved somewhere deep inside her,
like scripture,
like gospel,
like she'd be singin' me under her breath for years to come.*

But nah.

*She was just dancin' in my arms 'til the music changed.
And when it did?
She ain't stumble.
She ain't hesitate.
She just let go,
like a breeze slippin' past an open window.
Gone.*

*No fight.
No tears.
Not even a scene.
Just a slow blink, a soft smirk,
like she was thankin' me for the lesson.*

*And bruh, I ain't gon' lie
I thought I could double back,
slide in smooth like I never left,
hit her with that, "Damn, you still think 'bout me?"
But when I did?
She just laughed.*

*Ain't even the type of laugh you wanna hear
nah, this was that knowing laugh,
that I'm good, baby laugh,
that I don't even dream about you no more laugh.*

And man, I felt that.

*'Cause I spent all this time thinking I was the storm in her life,
but I ain't even leave a puddle.
She walked away dry,
left me drowning in my own ego.*

*And that?
That's the coldest game I ever got played in.*

I Taught Her How to Forget Me

*I gave her the blueprint,
the exit strategy,
the step-by-step manual on how to unlove a man like me.
Didn't even know I was doin' it*

*thought I was just movin' the way I always moved,
thought she'd always be waitin' right there,
soft hands, warm lips, open door.*

*But nah,
she studied every time I ain't answer,
took notes when I made her feel small,
highlighted the nights I chose the streets over her sheets.
She put all that shit in bold, underlined it twice,
then turned it into scripture.*

*I taught her patience,
but only in the way you learn waitin' for a train that don't ever
come.*

*Taught her silence,
but only 'cause she got tired of beggin' me to listen.
Taught her strength,
but only in the way you build muscle from carryin' a love that
was never meant to be light.*

*See, I ain't know I was showin' her the way out.
Didn't know every cold shoulder was a lesson in detachment,
every missed call was a practice round for forever.
Didn't realize I was training her to walk away without lookin'
back.*

*And when she left?
She ain't hesitate.*

Ain't no long texts, no please reconsider, no last kiss.

She just went.

Like she never been here.

Like I never mattered.

*Like she learned the trick of disappearin'
without even leavin' a shadow behind.*

*And now, I stand in rooms we used to fill,
say her name just to see if the walls remember.
But they silent.*

Just like she is.

Just like I taught her to be.

I Didn't Deserve Her

*She was a sun-drenched morning wrapped in silk,
and I was a long night that overstayed its welcome.
She came in like cinnamon and rosewater,
something you savor slow, something you sip on careful,
and I was rust in a crystal glass
something that look like wine 'til you taste it.*

*She wrote me in soft cursive,
letters pressed deep into the page,
like she thought we'd be read forever.
And I signed my name in vanishing ink,*

*smudged fingerprints, a story half-told,
a man who loved the idea of love but never the weight of it.*

*She poured patience in my wounds,
stitched my ego with thread spun from mercy,
kissed my history like she wasn't scared of ghosts.
And I?*

*I let her.
Took her softness like a thief with dirty hands,
wore her love like a winter coat in July,
flung it off soon as the heat got too real.*

*See, I didn't deserve her.
Didn't deserve the way she looked at me like I was the answer,
when I was just a riddle with no clean ending.
Didn't deserve the prayers she whispered with my name in 'em,
the way she carved space for me in a future I never earned.
Didn't deserve the way she tried
God, she tried
to build a home in a man who only knew how to be a locked door.*

*And now?
She's somewhere laughin' with a man who knows how to stay,
who don't flinch when love calls his name,
who don't mistake devotion for a cage.*

*And me?
I sit in rooms too quiet,*

*pour drinks too strong,
write poems too late.*

*But poetry ain't a time machine,
and apologies don't hold the weight of a woman who finally
learned
that loving me was just another way of losing herself.*

I Almost Called Her

*The idea of a call sat heavy in my hands,
like a glass I wasn't sure I wanted to shatter.
Her number still lived in muscle memory,
a ghost beneath my fingertips,
waiting to be summoned
waiting to remind me that I was once loved
by something softer than regret.*

*I almost called her.
Almost let the whiskey turn courage,
let the night slip its hands around my throat
and press out an apology too late to matter.
Almost let my voice be a door she thought was locked,
let my breath be the draft that stirred old ashes.*

*But what could I say?
That the silence between us felt like a sermon?
That I watched the moon some nights,*

*wondering if she still loved the way it spilled silver
across city streets and sleeping bodies?
That every woman I held after her
was just another way to hold my own mistakes?*

I almost called her.

*Almost begged for a chance to stand in the wreckage
and pretend I had the hands to rebuild.
Almost fed her my best performance,
the one where I finally know what love is,
the one where I've changed,
the one where I never let her down.*

But I ain't a good enough liar for that.

*Ain't delusional enough to pretend
I was anything more than a beautiful mistake
she finally learned to stop making.*

*So I set the phone down,
let the moment pass,
and sat in the quiet I earned.*

I Could Write Her a Thousand Poems

*I could write her a thousand poems,
each one dipped in the honey of Solomon's verses,
lined with the silk of a love too sweet to swallow.
But she don't read scripture no more,*

*and my voice ain't strong enough
to resurrect what died in her hands.*

*She was my garden,
spiced with longing,
lips like pomegranates split in the heat of July
but another man walked through her gates,
drank deep from her well,
and left me outside the walls,
begging for a taste of what was mine.*

*She told me love was patience,
but she never waited.
Told me love was trust,
but she never trusted me.
Told me love was sacrifice,
but I was the only one bleeding.*

*I could write her a thousand poems,
but they'd only collect dust
like the prayers I stopped saying.
Like the "come back" I swallowed whole.
Like the man I could've been,
if she just believed in me enough to stay.*

*She was supposed to be my crown,
my Proverbs 31,
the woman wise enough to see the king in me*

*but maybe I was just another fool,
sitting in the ruins of a throne
I was never meant to wear.*

VI. The Wisdom of Wounds

I Was Her Temptress

*I ain't never been no saint,
but I ain't never been no devil neither.
I just held out my hand,
and she put hers in it.
That ain't a sin, is it?*

*She say I led her to ruin,
but she was already walkin' barefoot on glass
long before I came whisperin' in her ear.
She called me temptation,
like I was somethin' forbidden,
somethin' dangerous
but I was just a mirror,
and she ain't like what she saw.*

*Ain't it funny, how a woman
can make you her weakness,
but blame you for her fall?
Like I ain't stumble too.*

*Like I ain't wake up with her ghost on my lips,
prayin' for a woman I never learned to deserve.*

*She tellin' folks I wrecked her,
left her love-dizzy and ruined,
but she the one who packed up her heart
and put it in another man's hands.
Now I'm the one watchin' from the door,
swearin' I ain't bitter,
but wonderin' how my arms went empty
when I was the one she couldn't get enough of.*

*If I was her mistake,
why she still say my name
like it taste too good to forget?*

The Cost of a King

*The throne was never built to last
gold-leaf promises peeling,
velvet sins unraveling at the seams.
I sat high, above love, above guilt,
above the wreckage of every woman
who ever knelt before me.*

*I called it a kingdom.
But glass don't hold weight,
and I was heavy with the ghosts of my own making.*

*She told me once "**Karma don't care about crowns.**"*

*I laughed,
thought I was untouchable,
thought my name was carved in the marble of memory.*

*But marble cracks.
And memory fades.*

*Now my castle is a mausoleum,
my throne a coffin,
my kingdom nothing but dust
blown back into my eyes.*

*I reach for mirrors that show me nothing.
I speak to echoes that won't answer:
I beg for women who only remember
how I made them forget themselves.*

*This is the weight of a king who ain't real.
This is the gold of my life, melting into rust.*

Too Wise to Be Saved

*I was never the fool. Never the one caught slippin'.
I had a playbook so thick, even karma had to flip through it
twice.
Knew how to hold a woman like a prayer
without ever kneeling,*

*how to make 'em whisper my name
like scripture they never meant to believe in.
I spoke in riddles, in half-truths wrapped like gold chains,
said just enough to keep 'em reaching
never enough to let 'em catch me.*

*But knowledge ain't wisdom.
And wisdom don't keep you warm at night.
You can master the game and still lose the house.
You can hold the map, trace every road back to her hands,
and still get lost.
I shoulda known that. I shoulda seen it coming.*

*But I never thought the day would come
where my own reflection wouldn't look me in the eye.
Where my own voice would feel like a stranger's.
An open Bible sits on my nightstand
I ain't touched it in years,
but somehow, the words keep flipping themselves open
like they waiting for me to listen.
Like they know the weight I carry.
Like they know how heavy regret sits in a man's bones.*

*And now, my shadow won't even stand beside me.
I cut my own strings thinking I was free,
but a puppet without a master
ain't nothing but limp wood and silence.*

*I was too wise to be saved,
too proud to be humble,
too empty to be full.
And maybe, just maybe,
too late to be anything else.*

When The Music Stopped

*I used to walk in a room and feel the bass bow down.
Women turned when I spoke,
men nodded when I moved
I was the song that got stuck in your head,
the chorus you couldn't help but sing.*

Now?

*The record skips.
The track ran out.
And I'm still standing here,
watching the smoke clear like I wasn't the one that lit the fire.*

*The club is empty now.
A few tables flipped, glasses half-drunk,
ghosts of last night still clinging to the walls.
Used to be, I was the noise, the reason the night stayed
wide-eyed.
Now I'm just silence,
listening to my own heartbeat
like it's the only rhythm left.*

*Checked my phone no missed calls.
No where you at?,
no come back, baby.
Just a screen as black as the space I take up.*

*Once, I had 'em wrapped around my fingers,
playing 'em like a DJ with a fresh vinyl,
spinning 'em into love,
remixing their pain into something they could dance to.
Now?
Ain't nobody left on the floor but me.*

*I used to move crowds.
Now I move alone.
The music stopped.
And the only thing left playing
is regret.*

I Built My Own Hell

*I ain't fall. Let's get that straight.
Ain't no trip, no push, no trick of fate.
I walked in with my chest out,
head high like I was immune to flame,
like the fire was just another woman
I could whisper my way into.
Like heat only burns the weak.*

*But fire don't care who you think you are.
And when the smoke cleared,
all that was left was me
hands covered in soot,
heart blackened like the bed of ashes I made myself lay in.*

*I used to call this place a kingdom.
Used to think power meant how many loved me,
how many cried my name into their pillows,
how many turned back just once before walking away.
Now my throne is a chair with three legs,
wobbling under the weight of my own doing,
and the echoes in these walls ain't begging me to stay
they're laughing.*

Mocking.

*Repeating every lie I ever told a woman
like a mixtape on repeat,
reminding me that the devil don't always come knocking
sometimes he just waits for you to come home.*

I built this.

Brick by brick.

*Every game I played, every love I faked,
every time I left and thought the road back would stay open.
I stacked my sins like poker chips,
betting against the house,*

thinking luck was loyalty.

Thinking I was the only one who'd never have to pay.

But the thing about hell?

Ain't no doors.

No exits.

No arms waiting to pull you back.

*Just you and the weight of everything you ever did,
piled high like an unmade bed you too ashamed to lay in.*

I built my own hell.

And I live here now.

No One Prays for Players

Ain't nobody light candles for men like me.

*Ain't no hymns sung soft for the ones who had it all
and let it slip between ringed fingers and whispered names.*

No tear-streaked cheeks call out for my soul.

No mother on her knees asking God to bring me home safe.

The pews stay empty where my name should be.

I walk past a church, doors bolted shut.

I knock. Ain't nobody answer.

God don't talk loud to men who only listen in loss.

*Only sound I hear is the wind through the cracks,
like a breath too tired to speak my sins aloud.*

*I remember women that once called me king,
hands on my chest, praying in ways I didn't deserve.
Now they don't speak my name. Not in love.
Not in hate.
Not at all.*

*The only mouths that mention me
do it with regret heavy on their tongues,
like my name is something bitter they can't swallow.
"Shoulda known better."
"Shoulda never answered that call."
"Shoulda left when I had the chance."
Shoulda. Shoulda. Shoulda.*

*I am a lesson wrapped in velvet and cigarette smoke,
a ghost with a body, walking through rooms
where no one looks up anymore.*

*Who prays for the man who played himself?
Who cries for the fool who ran toward the flood,
dared the waves to take him,
and then screamed for a rope when the tide pulled too strong?*

*Ain't no mercy for a man who knew better.
Ain't no redemption for the one who ran toward the storm
with a smile on his lips,
thinking the rain could never drown him.*

I Thought I Had Time

*I walked like the sun would never set on me,
like the streetlights would hold their glow just a little longer,
like I could take the long way home
and still find her porch light burning.*

*I thought love had no expiration date,
that apologies never spoiled,
that regret was just a word
and not a weight with a name.*

*I thought I had time
to fix the wreckage,
to unburn the bridges,
to say "I love you"
without it sounding like a eulogy.*

*But time don't wait for men who whisper "tomorrow."
It don't stop for hands too proud to knock,
for lips too stubborn to speak first.
It don't care how bad I want to rewind,
how many nights I sit in silence,
waiting for a voice that ain't coming back.*

*Now, her name is a prayer I ain't got the right to say.
Her memory is a door that don't swing both ways.
And the clock God, that clock
ain't got no hands left for me.*

God, Are You Still There?

Knees pressed into a floor that never learned my name,

palms folded like they knew what mercy was,

mouth open but only silence comes out

ain't that just like me? Always late, always empty.

The ceiling don't move when I whisper.

The air don't shift when I breathe Your name.

Ain't no fire, no thunder, no proof You still listening,

but I ain't got nowhere else to turn.

I been king of ruin, prince of regret,

carved my throne from women's ribs,

drank loyalty like it couldn't run dry

but it did. Lord, You know it did.

I called love a weakness,

called loss a game,

called faith a fairytale

until I woke up alone.

Her perfume still lingers in the air like a prayer I never answered,

her silence stretches wider than the grave I dug for us.

I wore betrayal like a coat made of wolf fur,

but damn, God, it's cold now.

I ran with devils who laughed in smoke rings,

who taught me sin like a second language,

who kissed my knuckles and told me power ain't free.

I paid every price but peace.

The mirrors don't even hold my face no more,

just a hollow thing shaped like a man,

a shadow that can't outrun itself.

Ain't that what hell is?

I ain't praying for a second chance.

I know what I did, know where I been,

know the blood ain't dried on my hands yet,

but damn, Lord, I miss being clean.

I miss waking up without the weight of ghosts,

miss love before I poisoned it,

miss mornings that didn't taste like regret.

I ain't asking to be saved, just to be seen.

I hear my own voice echo in the stillness,

bouncing off these walls like a sermon with no audience.

The wind moves, just barely,

and for a second, I swear it ain't mine.

Maybe that's You. Maybe it ain't.

Maybe grace is just a debt You don't collect on time.

Maybe You let men like me kneel in the wreckage

just long enough to remember who built it.

I ain't asking You to fix it.

I ain't asking for the past to unburn.

I just wanna know if You still watch men like me,

or if I buried myself too deep to be found.

The silence don't change.

The sky don't crack open.

But my hands still shake when I say Your name,

and for the first time, I think that's enough.

God, are You still there?

I don't deserve an answer,

but I ask anyway.

The Uncrowned King

I stand among the ruins of my kingdom,

Throne toppled, crown shattered, subjects gone

Not by enemy's hand or rival's sword,

But by my own design, my own undoing.

I built an empire on shifting sands,

On bodies I never held till morning,

On promises whispered but never kept,

On hearts collected then discarded.

*Solomon had wisdom, had wealth, had women
A thousand lovers to warm his bed,
A thousand songs to praise his name,
A thousand prayers to bless his reign.*

*And I? I chased his shadow,
Mistook conquest for power,
Mistook desire for love,
Mistook fear for strength.*

*They called me king, and I believed them.
They knelt before me, and I accepted it.
They gave me their bodies, and I took them.
They offered their hearts, and I refused them.*

*For what is a king who must surrender?
What is a ruler who must be ruled?
What is a god who must be human?
I was too afraid to find out.*

*But kingdoms fall, and crowns tarnish,
And even Solomon, in all his glory,
Found himself humbled before greater powers
Time. Truth. Consequence. Love.*

*These are the real rulers, the true sovereigns,
The forces that bring even kings to their knees,*

*That strip away pretense and performance,
That reveal the man beneath the myth.*

*She saw it first the woman who wouldn't kneel.
She looked at me with eyes too clear, too knowing,
And said, "You're not Solomon, baby.
You're just a man who likes the sound of his own name."*

*And I hated her for that truth,
For that mirror she held up without mercy,
For seeing the boy hiding in the man's clothes,
For knowing I was more costume than king.*

*Then came the one who prayed for me,
Who held my hands like they were something holy,
Who saw past the walls I'd built so high
To the broken foundation underneath.*

*She loved me not for my performance,
Not for my crown or my conquests,
But for the man she believed I could be
If I just had the courage to try.*

*And I ran from that too
Ran from her faith, her hope, her love,
Ran from the possibility of becoming
Something more than my father's son,*

*Something more than my fears and failures,
Something more than the sum of my sins.*

*I ran until there was nowhere left to go,
Until I found myself back where I started.
Alone.*

*This is the wisdom wounds teach us:
That power without purpose is just noise,
That pleasure without connection is just emptiness,
That pride without humility is just delusion.*

*This is the lesson Solomon learned too late:
That all the wives in the world can't fill
The space where love should be,
That all the gold can't warm a cold heart.*

*So here I stand in the aftermath,
In the quiet after the storm,
In the stillness after the fall,
In the silence after the music stops.*

*I have no crown, no throne, no kingdom
Just these hands that have held too much
And kept too little,
Just this heart that has wanted too much
And given too little.*

*But maybe that's where rebuilding begins
Not with grand gestures or royal decrees,
Not with conquest or collection,
But with the simple act of surrender.*

*Of saying, "I was wrong."
Of saying, "I am sorry."
Of saying, "I am afraid."
Of saying, "I need help."*

*Perhaps the true measure of a king
Is not how many subjects he commands,
But how many times he can fall
And still find the strength to rise.*

*Not how many hearts he can conquer,
But how many lives he can touch.
Not how many women he can possess,
But how deeply he can love just one.*

*I am not Solomon. I never was.
I am just a man with scars and stories,
With regrets and possibilities,
With a past I cannot change
And a future I can still shape.*

*I am just a man learning, finally,
That the greatest wisdom comes not from ruling,*

*But from serving;
Not from taking,
But from giving;
Not from hardening,
But from opening.*

*The kingdom I thought I built has fallen,
But from its ashes, something new might rise
Not an empire of conquest and collection,
But a sanctuary of truth and connection.*

*Not a throne built on fear and performance,
But a home founded on courage and presence.
Not a crown that separates and elevates,
But a circle that includes and embraces.*

*This is my uncrowned glory,
My throned humility,
My powerful surrender.*

*This is my song of Solomon,
Not as he was in legend and lore,
But as he might have been
In his quietest moments,*

*When the crown was set aside,
When the throne room was empty,
When he was just a man*

*Facing the same stars we all face,
Asking the same questions we all ask:*

*Did I love well?
Did I live fully?
Did I learn what matters?*

*And finding, perhaps,
That the answers were always
Simpler than he thought,
Closer than he knew,
Waiting in the spaces between heartbeats,
In the silence between words,
In the warmth between bodies,
In the trust between souls.*

*I am the uncrowned king,
The ruler who finally learned to be ruled,
The conqueror who finally learned to surrender,
The man who finally learned to be human.*

*And maybe that's enough.
Maybe that's everything.*

Back Matter

Author's Note

When I began writing these poems, I had no intention of creating a collection, let alone one that traced a journey from conquest to contemplation. Each piece emerged from a moment sometimes of triumph, sometimes of loss, sometimes of that peculiar emptiness that follows getting exactly what you thought you wanted. I wrote about love the way I experienced it: as a game, a battlefield, a transaction. I wrote about women as conquests, as mirrors, as ghosts. I wrote about myself as untouchable, unbreakable, unstoppable. But somewhere along the way, the writing itself became a mirror I couldn't look away from. The words revealed patterns I hadn't wanted to see, truths I hadn't been ready to face. The man on these pages arrogant, afraid, always running was me, stripped of pretense and performance. This collection represents not just a creative journey, but a personal reckoning. The Solomon figure who begins these poems believing himself a king ends them understanding what true power looks like: the courage to be vulnerable, the strength to be honest, the wisdom to be still. I don't claim to have completed this journey in my own life. Some days I'm still that man in the first section, believing his own mythology. But in creating this collection, in arranging these pieces into a narrative of fall and potential redemption, I've created a map for myself a way forward through the ruins of what I once thought defined me. My hope is that these poems speak to anyone who has ever mistaken conquest for connection, who has ever hidden behind a crown of their own making, who has ever stood in the wreckage of their own design and wondered if rebuilding is possible. It is. That's the promise these poems

make. Not that the rebuilding will be easy or that the new structure will resemble the old, but that from ruins, something authentic can emerge something not built on fear, but on truth.

Thank you for walking this path with me.

Acknowledgments

To the women who appear in these pages some composites, some all too real thank you for the lessons, even the painful ones. Especially the painful ones.

*To my mother, who never stopped believing there was a better man inside me, even when I gave her every reason to doubt your faith was a light I ran from until I was ready to be found. To the mentors who pushed me to dig deeper, to write truer, to face the page with honesty even when honesty hurt your challenges made this collection what it is. To the readers who find themselves in these words whether in the swagger of the early poems or the humility of the later ones I see you. I was you. In some ways, I am still you. We're all just trying to figure out how to be human in a world that often rewards us for being anything but. And finally, to myself the **boy** I was, the **boy** I am, the **man** I'm trying to become grace. Always grace. The journey continues.*

About the Author

Kiminou Knox is a writer, athlete, and creative force emerging from East Palo Alto, California. A poet and storyteller with a voice both sharp and introspective, he crafts narratives that explore the weight of history, the search for identity, and the deep- rooted spiritual and cultural legacies that shape Black existence. At just 18, he has already made his mark with Poems from a Black Boy, weaving words that pulse with emotion, truth, and an unflinching gaze at the realities of life. With Spirit of Solomon his Sophomore Title, Kiminou delves into themes of legacy, resilience, and the unseen forces that bind us to our past. His work bridges the poetic and the profound, drawing readers into layered stories that challenge, heal, and ignite something raw within the soul. Beyond writing, he carries the discipline of an athlete, the vision of an entrepreneur, and the spirit of a storyteller determined to leave an impact. As he moves toward a future literature and sports journalism, his voice continues to grow one that demands to be heard, one that refuses to be forgotten.

